

Small Group Bible Study Series

Galatians 1:11-17

Paul's Independent Revelation

(Independent of Human Teaching)

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① The Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
<i>Foundation</i>	<i>Personal prep</i>	<i>Leader / Teacher</i>	<i>Group together</i>
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① THE BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Read together before anything else

Galatians 1:11-17

11 *But I make known to you, brethren, that the gospel which was preached by me is not according to man.*

12 *For I neither received it from man, nor was I taught it, but it came through the revelation of Jesus Christ.*

13 *For you have heard of my former conduct in Judaism, how I persecuted the church of God beyond measure and tried to destroy it.*

14 *And I advanced in Judaism beyond many of my contemporaries in my own nation, being more exceedingly zealous for the traditions of my fathers.*

15 *But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother's womb and called me through His grace,*

16 *to reveal His Son in me, that I might preach Him among the Gentiles, I did not immediately confer with flesh and blood,*

17 *nor did I go up to Jerusalem to those who were apostles before me; but I went to Arabia, and returned again to Damascus.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Heart preparation · read in the days before your group meets

“Salvation is free. If you believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, you have eternal life — and nothing is added to that. Not one thing.”

Paul was not defending an opinion in these verses — he was defending a revelation. Judaizers had slipped into the churches of Galatia insisting that grace plus law-keeping made the real gospel. Paul reminds these believers that his message never came from a man, a committee, or a classroom — it came straight from the risen Christ. Every man-made religion, he says, carries its own “you must” column, some penalty attached for failing to keep it. Paul’s gospel carried none.

That claim carries even more weight once you remember who is making it. This was a man who had hunted down Christians, dragged them from their homes, and stood in approval while they died — about as far from “gracious” as a person could be. If God could reach a man like that with pure, unearned grace in Christ, He can reach you, on your worst day, too.

God did not wait for Paul to clean himself up first. He set him apart before Paul had done a single thing to deserve it, called him by grace alone, and sent him — of all people — to the very Gentiles he had once despised. Grace runs ahead of our worthiness every time.

Reflect:

1. Where in your life are you tempted to quietly add a “must” to God’s free gift?
2. Paul’s transformation began before he had done anything to earn it. Where do you see God’s grace running ahead of your own effort?
3. Is there a person or group you’ve written off, the way Paul once despised the Gentiles? How might grace be calling you toward them?

Lord, thank You that Your grace reaches people long before they deserve it — including me.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition: The gospel Paul preached — salvation by grace through faith alone in Christ alone — did not originate with man, was not handed to him by man, and was not taught in any human school. It came by a direct revelation of Jesus Christ, and it was validated by a transformed life only God could explain.

Salvation is free. If one believes, if you believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, then you have eternal life. And nothing is added to that, not one thing. No works of any kind. I think that maybe their response would be, and maybe your response too, well wait a minute, Paul made that up because Paul was the first one to really stress it, to lay it out. Remember, Paul taught that to the Galatians in the Galatia area. After he came back, remember, that some people came in through there, some Judaizers. They were Jews, maybe believers, but they had the gospel wrong. That is, they had the wrong idea about how you live it. So, they were coming in Jesus' name, preaching this different gospel, and Paul told us about that last week, it is not of God. The salvation is by grace. Plus, not one thing. So they may have thought, I think Paul made that up. How come Paul got this special idea? I don't think he's going to do that. So Paul now, I think, puts in this paragraph, he's saying, I want you to know that this did not come from me. It came from God. It's a revelation, and we'll see that. Now, he starts off in the verses 11 and 12 by saying, Paul's claim, Paul's claim, you see here in your outline, Paul's claim was that he had a divine revelation. God told it to him. God gave him this revelation.

I. Paul's Claim: A Divine Revelation — 1:11-12

A. His Gospel Is Not According to Man — 1:11

Now, he says in verse 11, This gospel was not according to man. He said, But I make known to you, brethren, that the gospel which was preached by me is not according to man. Man did not make it up. He's writing to the Galatian believers, to them, to the believers, the people in the pew. He was not writing to these Judaizers. There are two groups, the Galatians and to the Judaizers. He mentions both. Whenever he says the word brethren, he uses that word 11 times in Galatians. He's talking to the people in the pew. The second group, he does not call brethren. The only people who are brethren are the born-again believers, people who have believed in Jesus for their salvation. They are the brethren. So he's talking to the believers, the people who heard his message and believed it. Now, the second group he calls cursed. He calls them that twice in verses 8 and 9. Now, so the gospel he had preached among them refers to the gospel he preached during the first missionary journey. They believed and they were saved. And so now, he's telling them that that gospel did not come from man, as the Judaizers no doubt had been telling them, primarily because men would not come up with that kind of a gospel. Any gospel that is from men is going to have a lot of things attached to it. I Googled the word world's religion. There must have been a hundred of them there. There was a chart what you believe and what you must do in order to get whatever they were offering, that is eternal life or whatever. But every, every, every religion had some things that you had to add to

believing. There was some penalty that would happen to you if you didn't do these other things. Now, eternal death even, because of you didn't follow all these man-made things. Now, that's the way a man's religion always looks. And Paul wants to make sure they know that he did not get it from man. It was not according to man. So, it was not according to man. That is, it was not fabricated.

B. His Gospel Did Not Come from Any Human Source — 1:12a

Then his gospel did not come from any man. No human source came where the gospel came from. So, it was also not imitation. not fabrication, and not imitation. He said, I neither received it from man. Not only did man not design it, he did not give it to Paul. So, the gospel did not come through any agency of mankind and he'll give the details of that in chapter two.

C. His Gospel Did Not Come from Any Course of Instruction — 1:12b

Now, thirdly, he says, the gospel did not come from any course of instruction. It was not assimilated. He didn't have to go somewhere and learn that gospel. He was taught it. In verse 12b, he said, Nor was I taught it, but came through the revelation of Jesus Christ. Straight from Jesus Himself. See, Paul didn't go to some school of Christianity. He didn't go to like they did in Judaism. He went to that. He went to Gamaliel and he studied under Gamaliel. He was an authority. on the law. But he said, I didn't go to that. It was not a fabrication, it was not an imitation, it was not an assimilation, it was a revelation, a revelation of Jesus Christ. And just like the other 12, they learned from Jesus Christ. He himself became an apostle and he got it right through Jesus Christ. How many years did the apostles, the other 12, how many years were they with Jesus? About three. Yeah, about three. Paul went into the Arabian desert. Guess how long he was there? Three years. And he had it one-on-one. He didn't have one speaking to twelve. He had one-on-one dialogue with Jesus Christ. That's where he got his revelation. We'll see it. Paul's claim, then, was a divine revelation.

II. Paul's Conduct before Conversion — 1:13-14

A. His Conduct with the Church — 1:13

Paul's conduct, he wants to tell you now, here's what I did. Here's my conduct. before his conversion. Note, don't lose contact with the context. Paul is showing how he was not predisposed to receive some kind of a special gospel. He was a Jew of the Jews. So, Paul is showing them he was not prejudiced to receive some kind of a gospel awakening the law. No. On the contrary, he fought against that kind of a gospel. He was saying the law has to be there. Verse 13, look at it. He says his conduct with the church. For you have heard of my, that is my own former conduct in Judaism, how I persecuted the church of God beyond measure and tried to destroy it. He tried to do away with this church because they did not follow the law. Now, they, that is the Judaizers, were following the law. Paul persecuted the church. Acts 8, verse 1, at that time, the time of Stephen's death, a great persecution arose with the church that is in Jerusalem. Verse 3, he says, as Paul, as for Paul, Saul, his name was Saul, then he had a Gentile named Paul, but as for Saul, he made havoc of the church. entering every house and dragging off men and women, committing them to prison. For what? For preaching this gospel, for this being a part of the church. In Acts chapter 9, verses 1 and 2, it says, Then Paul, still

breathing out threats and murder against the disciples of the Lord, went to the high priest and asked him letters to the synagogues of Damascus, so that he could, if he found any who were of the way, what's the way? That's the church. Jesus said, I am the way, the truth, and the life. And the church was called the way early in the church. So if any men who were of this way, whether they were men or women, he might bring them bound back to Jerusalem, for some of them caused them to die for death. Also, Paul's own testimony before Herod, Acts chapter 26, all the way down near the end of his life. He was taken captive, on his way to going to take him over to Rome, put him in prison for preaching the same gospel that he had been against. He stopped along the way and they moved him up to Herod Agrippa. He says this before Herod, explaining his own life. He says, Indeed, I myself thought I must do many things contrary to the name of Jesus Christ, the Jesus of Nazareth. This I also did in Jerusalem. Many of the saints I shut up in prison, having received authority from the chief priests. When they were put to death, I cast my vote against them. And I punished them often in every synagogue, and compelled them to blaspheme, and made exceedingly enraged against them. I persecuted them even to foreign cities. Paul was a busy man prior to his salvation, busy against the church now he also says in Philippians 3:6 concerning zeal I was persecuting the church now he was not just trying to hurt the church he was trying to eradicate it in Galatians 1:13 it says this and tried to destroy it and didn't yet know that Jesus had himself had said On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. See even Paul, no matter how powerful, how important, how dedicated he was, he could not prevail against the Church of God. This is like the blacksmith. The blacksmith was hammering on his anvil with his hammer. Somebody asked him, How many anvils has that hammer ruined? He says, None. But that anvil has ruined hundreds of hammers. And that's what happens. People are hammering against the church, hammering all kinds of things, messing up their speaker system so they can't hear the word, make them look at their hymnals. Yeah. Satan gets in there. He uses some of our failures to do the same thing. What I'm saying to you though is the church is not going to be discerved. The church will prevail. as God had promised it. So, the hammers are being broken. The church stands still. His conduct with the church, that was.

B. His Conduct in Judaism — 1:14

Now, his conduct with Judaism. He says in verse 14, I advanced in Judaism beyond many of my contemporaries, in my own nation, even more exceedingly zealous for the traditions of my fathers. He advanced, he went forward. In fact, he was zealous of the traditions of the fathers. Now, on the surface, you think, well, that's the tradition of Israel's fathers. No, I think what he's saying here is, my father, Paul's father, he knew what his father had said, and his grandfather had said that. In other words, his fathers taught him that, he was not going against that, he was going straight with that. It goes much farther than the law. The law was there. It was given in Exodus 19 and 20. But what happens is the Pharisees have put a hedge around the law. 613 human commandments around the law. You couldn't get to the law. But they said, well, the law teaches this. And then all these 613 commands had to be done. That really messed up Judaism. It was no longer from the God of Israel. It was against the God of Israel. And these human commandments caused many clashes between Jesus and the Pharisees. 13, he says this, But woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites, for you shut up the kingdom of God against men, but you neither go in yourselves, nor do you allow those who are entering to go in.

The Pharisees were actually keeping people away from God. Sometimes read that entire chapter. It was Matthew 23:13. Read that entire chapter. You won't be able to put it down. I guarantee you. That is an amazing chapter. All the people that come against Jesus, He just throws the words at them and knocks them down in that sense. But do it. You'll enjoy it. Some Pharisees had been saved and some of them were going off. They had salvation. But they were saying, Now this is what you have to do. You have to keep this law, the law, the law, the law. They were trying to make that apply to salvation. Now, so Paul, the strongest defender of these traditions, was now the strongest supporter of Christianity, of Christian liberty. So, he convinced those legalists of Jerusalem later on that the law was indeed done away by the death of Christ. as far as salvation goes. So in Acts 15, read that sometime. Acts 15 Paul goes to Jerusalem, talks to them about this gospel and they decide, yes, Paul is right. And Peter was on the same track. Peter is right too. All that is to say that the law had been done away. I think the Scripture says clearly that the law is done away totally. The Mosaic Law is not in effect now. I hope you'll come and ask me about that. I'd love to talk to you about it. So Paul's claim then was a divine revelation. His conduct before his conversion showed that he was not shaded in any way in his mind toward some kind of a gospel, a part of the law.

III. Paul's Call to Preach — 1:15-16a

A. God's Preparation — 1:15

1. He Brought Him Forth — 1:15a

And then Paul's call is to preach, verses 15 and 16. Paul's preparation was this. He brought me forth. Now, he brought Paul forth. But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother's womb. This is his birth. Now, the separation is not just being born. All babies who are born are brought forth from the mother's womb. But he's referring here to being set apart for service. one who separated me from the very time of my birth. He separated me to be a minister of the gospel of Jesus Christ. Just like Jeremiah 1:5. Jeremiah 1:5 says that he was separated from his mother's womb. Galatians 1:15, you'll see another illustration of that. Remember, before the foundation of the world, God chose you. before the foundation of the world, a long time ago.

2. He Sent Him Forth — 1:15b

So he brought him forth, but he also then sent him forth. 15b, He called me through his grace. Paul was separated from his other womb, called there, and then he was called through the grace of God. So Paul was sent forth to be an apostle of the Gentiles. The reference to The grace is Paul's acknowledgement that it was God's grace. God graciously called him, not because he deserved it, but because God wanted to use him. And he did. He didn't deserve to be a servant of the Lord. And I think if we all think about that, we don't deserve it either. We don't deserve this salvation. God didn't look at you and say, Oh, I like that guy. I think I'll take him. No. Oh, a lady. Here's a lady over here and I'll accept her. She's such a great woman. She'd be great for me. No. He gets dirty, rotten, filthy sinners. And you're all a bunch of them. That's it. You're it. But he cleans you up first and then sends you forth. That's what it is. So he brought him forth and then he sent him forth. That's his preparation.

B. God's Purpose — 1:16a

1. To Reveal His Son

But then why did God send him forth? The purpose. He sent him forth to reveal his son, to reveal his son in me. Wow. That's a message, isn't it? Not to reveal his son by my mouth, to reveal his son in me. If I'm preaching the gospel of Jesus Christ and I don't act like Jesus Christ, If I'm serving, saying all kinds of things and then doing all kinds of other things, that's not what he said. He wanted to serve, he wanted to present God, Christ, in me. In me. So, to reveal His Son. Now, what do you mean, His Son? Why didn't he say Jesus? Because he wanted to point out that it's not just Jesus, the man, It's Jesus, the Son. And that's what John chapter 20, verse 31. He says, These things, the Gospel, are written, the Gospel of John, are written, that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God. It doesn't stop there. It gets better. And believing you might have life through His name. That's the Gospel of John. And if you want to read What is the Gospel? John's Gospel has that avowed purpose of telling you, how do I believe? How do I receive salvation? All he mentions in there is believe, believe, believe. Sometimes go through your Gospel of John. Or we have some Gospels of John on the credenza out there. Take one. They're free. Go through there and circle the word believe. That's a good task. That's great. Believe, believe, believe, believe. How do you receive Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and how do you believe on His name? You believe. You believe what the Word of God says. 16 is the best scripture in the Bible, I think, one of the best. God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son. In order that, Whoever believes in Him should not perish, but have everlasting life. How long is everlasting? It is everlasting. Doesn't stop. That's his point here. So, he stresses Jesus' deity. And by the way, without Jesus' deity, then the whole entire message of the Word as Shakespeare would say, a tale told by an idiot, full of sound and fury, meaning nothing.

2. To Reach the Gentiles

Jesus, to present Jesus, the Christ, the Son of God, and to also to reach the Gentiles. Now, that I may preach Him among the Gentiles, all the ministries of the Apostle Paul might be called the strangest the strangest of all, the strangest imaginable. He's going to preach to the Gentiles. Do you know how much he hated Gentiles? Do you know how much he hated people who said you have to believe in Jesus to have eternal life? He hated them, put them in prison, killed them. And now Jesus said, Now, you're going to go to the Gentiles. What? You're going to go to the Gentiles. You see, you don't have to have an appreciation for people. Just recognize that God has appreciation for them. God so loved them and He's saying to you, I so love these people. Will you go there and take the Gospel to them? I don't like them. I don't care. Don't have to like them. One of these days, give them the Gospel. They'll be your brother, be your sister. That's it. So, to reach the Gentiles. to preach Jesus Christ. So, I think that we have to understand that being in the will of God is the best place to be. I think that Daniel might say, I'd rather be in a den of lions in the will of God than to be anywhere else out of the will of God. That's it. No matter what comes to you, and we may see that. We need to see that when it comes time to make a testimony, you make the testimony. So, Paul's claim was a divine revelation. His conduct before his conversion and then his call to preach.

IV. Paul's Course after Conversion — 1:16b-17

A. What He Did Not Do — 1:16b

Now, one more thing. Paul's course after his conversion. Let me just stop a minute. Remember Acts chapter 9, what happened to Paul. He got those documents to get people from anybody in the way. I'm going up there and I'm going to get those people out of Damascus. And just before he got there, the Lord struck him and knocked him off his horse and he said, Who are you? And he said, I am Jesus whom you persecute. That's before his salvation, of course. He was going up there to persecute the people. And that's how he got saved. The Lord knocked him off his horse and he says, Who are you, Lord? He said, I am Jesus whom you are persecuting. And from then on, Paul was a servant of Jesus Christ. Well, that's where he was, what he did not do.

1. He Did Not Confer with Any People

I did not immediately confer with flesh and blood. This excludes all people, all Jews, all Gentiles, all, all human beings are excluded.

2. He Did Not Meet with the Apostles

And he says, I did not go up to Jerusalem to those who were apostles before me. He especially didn't go up to Jerusalem and learn from them and then depart from that gospel to another gospel of his own. He didn't talk to them at all. So, that's what he did not do.

B. What He Did Do

1. He Went to the Desert

Now, here's what he did do. But, strong adversity. But I went to Arabia. Wow. If I am Damascus, Jerusalem is due south. I'll call that south. If Jerusalem is there, he didn't go there. He went over to Arabia, southeast. That's where he went. So I went instead to Arabia in the desert. He also received more revelation from the risen Lord. A large part of what Paul learned there can be seen in the book of Romans. If you want to hear what God told Paul in succinct form, Read the book of Romans. So that's your second assignment. Read the book of Romans. Romans has been called the Christian manifesto. You'll learn what Christianity is about when you read the book of Romans.

2. He Went Back to Damascus

And then he said, I went there and then I went back to Damascus. So I went from Arabia back up to Damascus now. Then Paul returned to Damascus and he ministered there for a while. And later on, they were after him because he was preaching the Word. They put him down, remember, a basket and they put it over the wall and Paul got down and went back to Jerusalem from there. He went back to Jerusalem later on.

Conclusion

So what he's saying is, the gospel came not from men, not from any of my imagination. It didn't come from any schooling. It came directly from the Lord. It came from a revelation of Jesus Christ Himself, who met him at the Damascus Road and sent him to Ananias, led him into the Arabian desert, and revealed to him the salvation is by faith alone in Christ alone. That's salvation. We get our revelation from the revelation. We learn what it is from what the Bible says. I heard a preacher this morning as I was getting ready. That preacher, a fine man, I've met him. I'm sorry, what he said, part of what he said was wrong. Why? How do I know that?

Because for the Word. If I wanted to, thought it was important, or if I thought he would listen, if I might go up there and say to him that was wrong well how do you know that here in the Word see that's it so faith alone in Christ alone and it came directly from the Lord what about you is that where your salvation is given you got your salvation from the Lord you believed on Him I believe what you say I believe you died in my place And I accept that salvation. It's a free gift. Free gift. How much do you pay for a free gift? Nothing. And that's the way God wants you to approach Him for salvation. Lord, I believe Jesus Christ died in my place. I will accept that free gift.

Lord, help us to do that. Help us to remember that we did it or make sure that we do it, because there's no other way and heaven is too great to miss just because we don't accept a free gift. In Jesus name. Amen.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Grammar	Definition & Significance
v.11	εὐαγγέλιον <i>gospel / good news</i>	Strong's G2098 <i>euangelion</i> Noun · Acc. Sg. Neut.	STR: Good news — the announcement of glad tidings, here of the message about Christ. <i>Significance in context: Paul insists this "good news" reports what God has already done in Christ — it is received, not achieved.</i>
v.12	ἀποκάλυψις <i>revelation</i>	Strong's G602 <i>apokalypsis</i> Noun · Gen. Sg. Fem.	THAY: A laying bare, an uncovering; disclosure of truth previously hidden. <i>Significance in context: Paul's authority rests entirely on what God unveiled to him — not on human insight refined over time.</i>
v.13	ἀναστροφή <i>conduct / manner of life</i>	Strong's G391 <i>anastrophē</i> Noun · Acc. Sg. Fem.	VINE: Used elsewhere (Eph. 4:22; 1 Pet. 1:15) of one's whole pattern of behavior, not a single act. <i>Significance in context: Paul cites an entire way of life engineered against grace — making his transformed message all the harder to explain by human causes.</i>
v.13	διώκω (ἐδίωκον) <i>I persecuted</i>	Strong's G1377 <i>ediōkon</i> Verb · Imperf. Ind. Act. · 1st Sg.	STR: To pursue, put to flight, persecute. <i>Significance in context: the same pursuing energy Paul once spent destroying the church, grace later redirected into building it.</i>
v.13	πορθέω (ἐπόρθουν) <i>was ravaging / destroying</i>	Strong's G4199 <i>eporthoun</i> Verb · Imperf. Ind. Act. · 1st Sg.	ATR: The imperfect pictures continuous, repeated action — an ongoing campaign, not one outburst. <i>Significance in context: the tense itself testifies this was sustained hostility, which makes Paul's reversal all the more clearly not self-generated.</i>
v.14	προκόπτω (προέκοπτον) <i>I was advancing</i>	Strong's G4298 <i>proekopton</i> Verb · Imperf. Ind. Act. · 1st Sg.	MRV: Pictures a pioneer cutting a path forward through undergrowth — the literal sense behind the figurative "advance." <i>Significance in context: Paul was cutting new ground ahead of his peers, making his later abandonment of legalism a costly reversal, not a convenient one.</i>
v.14	ζηλωτής <i>zealot / one who is zealous</i>	Strong's G2207 <i>zēlōtēs</i> Noun · Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: One burning with zeal; an ardent devotee. <i>Significance in context: sincerity alone never validates a gospel — Paul's zeal was genuine, yet misdirected until grace redirected it.</i>
v.14	παράδοσις (παραδόσεων)	Strong's G3862 <i>paradoseōn</i> Noun · Gen. Pl. Fem.	THAY: Precepts handed down by word of mouth or writing — here, the rabbinic oral traditions of the

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Grammar	Definition & Significance
	<i>traditions</i>		fathers. <i>Significance in context: the 'traditions of the fathers' had grown into 613 added commandments — a caution that sincere tradition can add to grace what grace never required.</i>
v.15	ἀφορίζω (ἀφορίσας) <i>having set apart / separated</i>	Strong's G873 <i>aphorisas</i> Verb · Aor. Act. Ptc. · Nom. Sg. Masc.	VINE: To mark off by a boundary, set apart for a special purpose (cf. Rom. 1:1). <i>Significance in context: God's setting apart of Paul precedes anything Paul believed or did — a call rooted in God's purpose, not Paul's merit, consistent with grace as an unconditional gift received by faith.</i>
v.15	χάρις (χάριτος) <i>grace</i>	Strong's G5485 <i>charitos</i> Noun · Gen. Sg. Fem.	STR: Unmerited favor; that which affords joy or delight; the divine favor freely given. <i>Significance in context: the hinge word of the passage — everything Paul is and does from here credits grace, not qualification, the same grace by which every believer receives eternal life the moment they believe.</i>
v.16	ἀποκαλύπτω (ἀποκαλύψαι) <i>to reveal</i>	Strong's G601 <i>apokalypsai</i> Verb · Aor. Act. Inf.	THAY: To uncover, disclose, make known what was before unknown. <i>Significance in context: the verb form of v.12's 'revelation' — what Paul knows and preaches, God uncovered; Paul only received and passed it on.</i>
v.16	ἔθνος (ἔθνεσιν) <i>nations / Gentiles</i>	Strong's G1484 <i>ethnesin</i> Noun · Dat. Pl. Neut.	LXX: In the Greek Old Testament, frequently designates the nations outside Israel's covenant people. <i>Significance in context: that God's Son would be preached "among the Gentiles" through Israel's most zealous defender is itself a mark of God's plan, not man's preference.</i>
v.16	προσανατίθεμαι (προσανεθέμην) <i>I conferred / consulted</i>	Strong's G4323 <i>prosanethemēn</i> Verb · Aor. Mid. Ind. · 1st Sg.	ATR: Middle voice — to lay a matter before another for advice; a deliberate personal choice, not an incidental omission. <i>Significance in context: Paul's independence from human confirmation protects the gospel's origin — had he sought approval first, the Judaizers could claim the message was reshaped by men.</i>

Grammar Abbreviation Key

Category	Abbreviations
Cases (Nouns / Adj.)	Nom. (Nominative) · Gen. (Genitive) · Dat. (Dative) · Acc. (Accusative) · Voc. (Vocative)
Number	Sg. (Singular) · Pl. (Plural)
Gender	Masc. (Masculine) · Fem. (Feminine) · Neut. (Neuter)
Verb Mood	Ind. (Indicative) · Imp. (Imperative) · Subj. (Subjunctive) · Opt. (Optative) · Inf. (Infinitive) · Ptc. (Participle)
Verb Tense	Pres. (Present) · Imperf. (Imperfect) · Fut. (Future) · Aor. (Aorist) · Perf. (Perfect) · Plpf. (Pluperfect)
Verb Voice	Act. (Active) · Mid. (Middle) · Pass. (Passive)
Verb Person / Number	1st Sg. / 1st Pl. · 2nd Sg. / 2nd Pl. · 3rd Sg. / 3rd Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Commentary Point	Reference
I. Paul's Claim: A Divine Revelation	1:11-12
II. Paul's Conduct before Conversion	1:13-14
III. Paul's Call to Preach	1:15-16a
IV. Paul's Course after Conversion	1:16b-17

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul says his gospel “did not come from man” in three ways. What are they, and why does the word ἀποκάλυψις (“revelation”) matter here?

Leader Answer: It was not designed by man, not handed to him through any human agency, and not taught to him through a course of instruction — it was revealed directly by Jesus Christ. ἀποκάλυψις means an unveiling of what was previously hidden; it grounds Paul's authority in God's initiative, not his own study or a teacher's instruction.

2. How does Paul's former conduct — persecuting and trying to destroy the church (v. 13) — actually strengthen his testimony rather than weaken it?

Leader Answer: A man so committed to destroying the church (note the imperfect tense of ἐπόρθουν — an ongoing campaign) had every reason to reject grace, not preach it. His transformation cannot be explained by human persuasion; it points to a real, divine encounter.

3. God “set apart” Paul “from his mother's womb” (v. 15) before Paul had done anything. What does ἀφορίσας (“having set apart”) teach about the timing of God's grace?

Leader Answer: The setting apart came before merit, before decision, before service — grace precedes and does not depend on the one being called (compare Jeremiah 1:5 and Ephesians 1:4).

4. Why did Paul deliberately avoid Jerusalem and the apostles after his conversion (vv. 16b-17), going instead to Arabia?

Leader Answer: So it would be unmistakable that his gospel was not shaped, corrected, or supplemented by human teachers — exactly what the Judaizers were denying. His message came from Christ alone (προσανεθέμην, “I conferred” — something he deliberately did not do), later confirmed but never originated by human counsel (Acts 15).

5. The sermon calls salvation “a free gift” that costs the receiver nothing. Based on Paul's own experience in this passage, how is that gift received?

Leader Answer: By faith alone — Paul received revelation, not wages; grace, not credentials. The same gospel he received without human help is offered to us without any addition of works: believe, and receive eternal life as a gift.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Focus	Summary
11-12	Divine Origin	Paul's gospel came neither from man's design, man's hand, nor man's classroom — but from a direct revelation of Jesus Christ.
13-14	Unlikely Messenger	Before his conversion, Paul was the gospel's fiercest enemy — advancing in Judaism and persecuting the church without restraint.
15-16a	Sovereign Call	God set Paul apart before birth and called him by grace alone to reveal His Son and reach the Gentiles.
16b-17	Independent Confirmation	Paul deliberately avoided human consultation, going to Arabia rather than Jerusalem, so no one could say his gospel came from men.

⑤ APPLICATION

Personal and corporate response — draws from all sections above

Resting in a Gospel You Didn't Invent

Scripture: *Galatians 1:11-12*

Source: *Commentary §I; Devotional*

Paul's confidence rested on the fact that his gospel came from revelation, not invention. The same is true for us: our standing before God is not something we composed, negotiated, or improved upon — it is something we received.

Reflection: Where are you tempted to treat your own reasoning, feelings, or effort as the real foundation of your assurance, rather than what God has revealed and finished in Christ?

Practical Step: This week, write down one thing you tend to lean on for assurance besides Christ's finished work, and replace it in prayer with a simple statement of what God has revealed.

Grace Reaches the Least Likely

Scripture: *Galatians 1:13-14*

Source: *Commentary §II*

Paul was the church's most committed enemy before he became its most tireless advocate. No one is too far gone, too hostile, or too zealous in the wrong direction for grace to reach.

Reflection: Is there someone you have quietly decided is beyond reach — too hardened, too hostile, too far along in the wrong direction?

Practical Step: Name that person this week and pray specifically for them, asking God to do for them what He did for Paul.

Called Before You Could Earn It

Scripture: *Galatians 1:15-16a*

Source: *Commentary §III; Self-Study Guide (ἀφορίσας, χάριτος)*

God set Paul apart from the womb, before Paul had believed, obeyed, or achieved anything. Every believer's calling rests on the same foundation — grace that precedes performance.

Reflection: How does it change your view of your own past, present, and future when you remember God's purpose for you did not begin with your qualifications?

Practical Step: Thank God specifically today for a purpose in your life that began before you could have earned it.

Letting the Gospel Stand on Its Own

Scripture: *Galatians 1:16b-17*

Source: *Commentary §IV; FGR.docx — Zane C. Hodges, Absolutely Free: A Biblical Reply to Lordship Salvation (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1989)*

Paul refused to let his gospel be reshaped by human committee or expectation. Hodges's classic Free Grace defense makes the same point for today's reader: a gospel of grace alone, received by faith alone, needs no additional human requirement to be genuine — adding one does not protect the gospel, it changes it.

Reflection: Where might you be tempted — for yourself or in what you teach others — to quietly add a requirement to simple faith in Christ?

Practical Step: Reread Galatians 1:16b-17 this week and identify one place where you can state the gospel to someone without adding anything to “believe.”

End of Study · Galatians 1:11-17